armored car and the light bomber, with their machine guns, pursue the bedouin into the desert, matching raid with swifter counter-raid. The farmer, with ever greater knowledge of water sources, pushes the margin of the sown out into the desert.

The friends of the bedouin have recognized the writing on the wall. Everywhere in the Middle East they are encouraging him to become a settled farmer. By the standards of his pinched life, any cultivable land is flowing with milk and honey. Yet the adjustment is not easy. In much of the Middle East the peasant cultivator carries the stigma of six centuries of serfdom, which came to an end legally only a century ago and has left a profound economic and social heritage. The bedouin does not want to become a serf. Moreover -- in contradiction to romantic belief -- the physique of the bedouin, sapped by desert privation is poor. He is physically, as well as psychologically, incapable of hard work. Moreover, he creates trouble in the rural community. He has little respect for life or property. He acquires land by squatting on it. Therefore his infiltration into the settled rural community is a fruitful source of land disputes. His attitudes toward life and property tend to lower an already lax rural public and private morality.

The Middle East's desert heritage is no romantic garland. Contact with the nomadic way of life means a low standard of public security, despite high security expenditures. It means backwardness in land cultivation and a tendency to prefer the less strenuous occupations of the herdsman (or the grain grower, who is idle between seeding and harvest) to the more strenuous, regular work required by intensive cultures. The population that has been driven from the desert by privation is poor in physique and little resistant to disease. Yet the settlement of the bedouin must continue -- on a large scale in Arabia, Transjordan, Iraq and Syria, and on a smaller scale in Palestine. The economic, social and political difficulties of adjusting a nomadic or semi-nomadic population to settled life must be borne because they are unavoidable.